litical antagonism evolved. The levels of acclaim from the anti-BJP flock—and alarm from the other side—rose in proportionate degrees as Mahua started taking a rather sharp inquisitorial tone on the issue of ports-to-energy tycoon Gautam Adani and his perceived proximity to Modi. In Parliament and on social media, she kept up a fusillade of searching questions on the Adani group's projects, funds flow, stock prices et al and allegations that the government had winked at violations. Even before short-selling firm Hindenburg dropped a bombshell in January 2023 by accusing the Adanis of "brazen stock manipulation and accounting fraud". In fact, when the Hindenburg Report came out, Mahua tweeted: "Glad that @HindenburgRes used my letters to @SEBI_India as part of their investigative work & reached a 'logical conclusion' even if SEBI couldn't!" It was only the rare peer—Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, a conspicuous one, also faced a disqualification drama—and the rare media outlet that she had for company. In fact, her targeted blitz on saffron politics in general too was so unremitting that the BJP couldn't have been faulted for asking itself the question: 'How to solve a problem like Mahua?' The answer was to come from the very questions Mahua asked on the floor of the House.

ENSEMBLE CAST

Dehadrai, who had flung the first allegations, is a Supreme Court lawyer with UPenn/ Wharton on his resume—he specialises, aptly enough, in white-collar crime and is described variously as "brilliant" and "arrogant" by acquaintances. His relationship with Mahua ended, evidently on a sour note, last December. Thereafter, Mahua seems to have filed multiple police complaints against him for alleged "vulgar messages, abuse, theft and criminal trespass"—two instances of the last charge are dated to March and September. One item Dehadrai wanted very keenly to retain ownership of is the Rottweiler Henry—he refers to himself as its 'father'. Mahua's own feelings for Henry were similarly apparent in a video that was all over social media. It may seem incredible that a custody battle over a dog could be at the centre of what's becoming one of India's biggest political controversies. But Henry inserts himself into this cast of volatile characters as an unlikely deus ex machina, though his bared canines in the video seem about the most innocuous of the weaponry on show. Dubey, the blunt-spoken MP from Godda, Jharkhand, is the son of a leftist who migrated saffronward in his youth and is now migrating upward in the BJP's estimation—from being just a part of their shouting brigade to one who was deemed good enough open the debate on the Women's Reservation Bill. He has an old beef with Mahua—she's the one who accused him of entering a non-existent MBA in his 2009 and 2014 election affidavit. Thus, his interests converged with that of Dehadrai: both were impelled by animus towards the same person.

But the allegations needed corroboration from a more crucial player. Darshan, who has admitted to being "a close personal friend" of Mahua's since 2017, supplied that. Credited with taking the Hiranandani real estate business beyond India, he's also said to be the brains behind the group's diversification into data centres, cloud computing, energy and industrial warehousing/ logistics. He is chairman of Yotta Data Services, oil and gas infra company H-Energy, Tarq Semiconductors and consumer services offering Tez Platforms. His aggressive growth instincts saw him sign an agreement with the Uttar Pradesh government in October last year to invest Rs 39,000 crore over five to seven

WHO, WHAT



On October 14, **lawyer Jai Anant Dehadrai** sends a 39-page letter to the CBI and **BJP MP Nishikant Dubey** with a litany of allegations against Mahua Moitra



The letter claims Mahua accepted luxury gifts/ cash from Dubai-based **businessman Darshan Hiranandani** for asking questions in the Lok Sabha against Gautam Adani's conglomerate



Among the alleged gifts were luxury brands like Salvatore Ferragamo, Berluti, Louis Vuitton, paid holidays and even cash

Dubey seeks proceedings against Mahua in the House ethics panel; also files a complaint with Lokpal

MAHUA MADE LIGHT OF HIRANANDANI'S APPROVER-LIKE AFFIDAVIT, SAYING IT WAS "DRAFTED BY THE PMO" AND SIGNED WITH "A GUN TO THE HEAD". BUT THE DAMAGE POTENTIAL WAS REAL